

ment, civic body and railways, shopkeepers in the milling bazaars, brokers at the Bombay Stock Exchange, lawyers in their chambers. After feeding time's done, he picks up the lunchboxes, and they transit through that same interlocking tracery of arteries and veins back to where they came from.

The passage through each successive node makes it a relay race, the baton often changing three or four hands. But make a moving digital map of the whole operation, its waves of integration and dispersal, and it's more akin to squadrons in formation flying. Except, it's one massive superorganism with multiple moving parts. Consider the numbers—at their pre-Covid peak, some 200,000 boxes in a day. Imagine massive shoals of fish and their uncannily synchronised swimming. In the unruly sea that's Mumbai, Gavande and his cohorts did this every day with an astounding 99.999999 per cent delivery accuracy rate. Just one error for every 16 million transactions. No wonder *Forbes* gave them a Six Sigma certification in 2001 and they came to be known as the gurus of logistics. Harvard studied them. So did IIM-Ahmedabad. And FedEx.

"Work From Home policy, job losses and food delivery apps have reduced our business hugely. Joining our profession has become very difficult for the new generation"

—SHANKAR DHUMAL, ***Dabbawala***

That spell of world renown may have been their crest. For now, almost a century and a half after they first began feeding the city, the dabbawalas fear their profession may be in retreat, their trademark Gandhi caps almost symbolising their anachronism. To understand this sense of an ending, one must look at the beginnings....